A Constructive Introduction to Quantum Field Theory

Forward–backward equations

Massimiliano Gubinelli | University of Oxford

SISSA lectures, Lecture 4 (provisional) — notes: Lecture 4, §§7–9, Appendices A–B

Where we are

So far. Stochastic quantisation of the GFF; the field at resolution t is a martingale of smooth fields; **observables** are martingales in the filtration of finite-resolution measurements.

Today. Interactions, still indexed by the **resolution** $t \in [0, T]$.

1. Generate the measure **three ways**: renormalisation, optimal control, filtering.
2. They meet in one system for a **field** and a **force**: the **force coordinates**.
3. Potentials: the value function generates them; Legendre; **Wetterich**.
4. Observables, and the **field equation** with its sub-Gaussian noise.

Caveat. Statements marked (formal) are exact in finite dimensions, with a terminal resolution $T < \infty$; the limits $T \to \infty$, $L \to \infty$ are the real problems. Bailleul–Chevyrev–G. (in prep.); Polchinski 1984; Bauerschmidt–Bodineau–Dagallier 2024

One measure, three constructions

Fix V_T and $\nu_T \propto e^{-V_T} \mu^{Q_T}$. Let $S_t = Q_T - Q_t$, the covariance still unresolved at resolution t.

- **Renormalisation.** Split the covariance into shells and integrate them out. At every resolution the field is again a Gibbs measure, driven by an effective force.
- **Optimal control.** Steer the Gaussian field by a drift, at the least cost. The effective potential is the value function, and the Polchinski equation is the dynamic programming equation.
- **Filtering.** Measure the terminal field with increasing precision. The conditional law is the posterior, and the regulator is the information gained.

They produce the same process.

Three ways to generate the interacting measure

Lecture 4

Effective potentials

Finite volume $\mathbb{T}_L^d$, terminal resolution $T < \infty$ (UV cutoff), interaction V_T bounded below, e.g.

$$V_T(\varphi) = \int_{\mathbb{T}_L^d} [\lambda H_4(\varphi; c_T) + \gamma_T H_2(\varphi; c_T)], \qquad \nu_T(\mathrm{d}\varphi) = Z_T^{-1} \mathrm{e}^{-V_T(\varphi)} \mu^{Q_T}(\mathrm{d}\varphi).$$

Definition. (Wilson effective action)

$$\mathrm{e}^{-V_t(\varphi)} := \int \mathrm{e}^{-V_T(\varphi+\zeta)} \, \mu^{Q_{T,t}}(\mathrm{d}\zeta), \qquad t \in [0, T].$$

The interaction felt at resolution t once the scales $[t, T]$ are integrated out; $V_0(0) = -\log Z_T$ is the free energy.

$$\mathrm{e}^{-V_t(X_t)} = \mathbb{E}_t^{\mathbb{P}_0}[\mathrm{e}^{-V_T(X_T)}]$$

Marginals and stochastic localisation

Proposition. (Marginals) $\mathrm{d}\mathbb{P}\,/\,\mathrm{d}\mathbb{P}_0 = Z_T^{-1}\mathrm{e}^{-V_T(X_T)}$. *Then* $\mathrm{Law}_{\mathbb{P}}(X_t) = \nu_t \propto \mathrm{e}^{-V_t}\mu^{Q_t}$, *and* $\mathrm{Law}_{\mathbb{P}}(X_T|\mathscr{F}_t) = \mu_t^{X_t}$, *the tilt of* $\mu^{Q_{T,t}}(\cdot - X_t)$ *by* e^{-V_T}.

- At every resolution the field is again a **Gibbs measure**: reference Q_t, potential V_t.
- The measure-valued martingale $t \mapsto \mu_t^{X_t}$ goes from ν_T $(t=0)$ to δ_{X_T} $(t=T)$: a **stochastic localisation** of ν_T (Eldan), adapted to the covariance profile.

Proof of the marginals. Under $\mathbb{P}_0$, $X_T = X_t + (X_T - X_t)$ with independent increment $\sim\mu^{Q_{T,t}}$, so

$$\mathbb{E}_{\mathbb{P}}[G(X_t)] = Z_T^{-1}\,\mathbb{E}_0\big[G(X_t)\mathrm{e}^{-V_T(X_T)}\big] = Z_T^{-1}\,\mathbb{E}_0\big[G(X_t)\mathrm{e}^{-V_t(X_t)}\big].$$

The Polchinski process

Theorem. (FBSDE for the interacting field) (formal) *Under* $\mathbb{P}$, *the* ***interacting field at resolution*** t, $\Phi_t := X_t$, *solves*

$$\mathrm{d}\Phi_t = \dot{Q}_t\, F_t\, \mathrm{d}t + \dot{Q}_t^{1/2}\, \mathrm{d}W_t^{\mathbb{P}}, \qquad F_t = -D\,V_t(\Phi_t) = \mathbb{E}_t^{\mathbb{P}}\left[-D\,V_T(\Phi_T)\right].$$

The ***effective force*** F *is a* $\mathbb{P}$*-martingale: an observable field of the interacting theory.*

Proof. Density process $M_t = Z_T^{-1} \mathrm{e}^{-V_t(X_t)}$. It is a martingale, so by Itô it has no drift, $\mathrm{d}M_t = -M_t \langle D\,V_t(X_t), \dot{Q}_t^{1/2} \mathrm{d}W_t \rangle$. Girsanov: $W_t^{\mathbb{P}} = W_t + \int_0^t \dot{Q}_s^{1/2}\, D\,V_s(X_s)\, \mathrm{d}s$. Finally $D\,V_t(\phi) = \mu_t^{\phi}\,(D\,V_T)$.

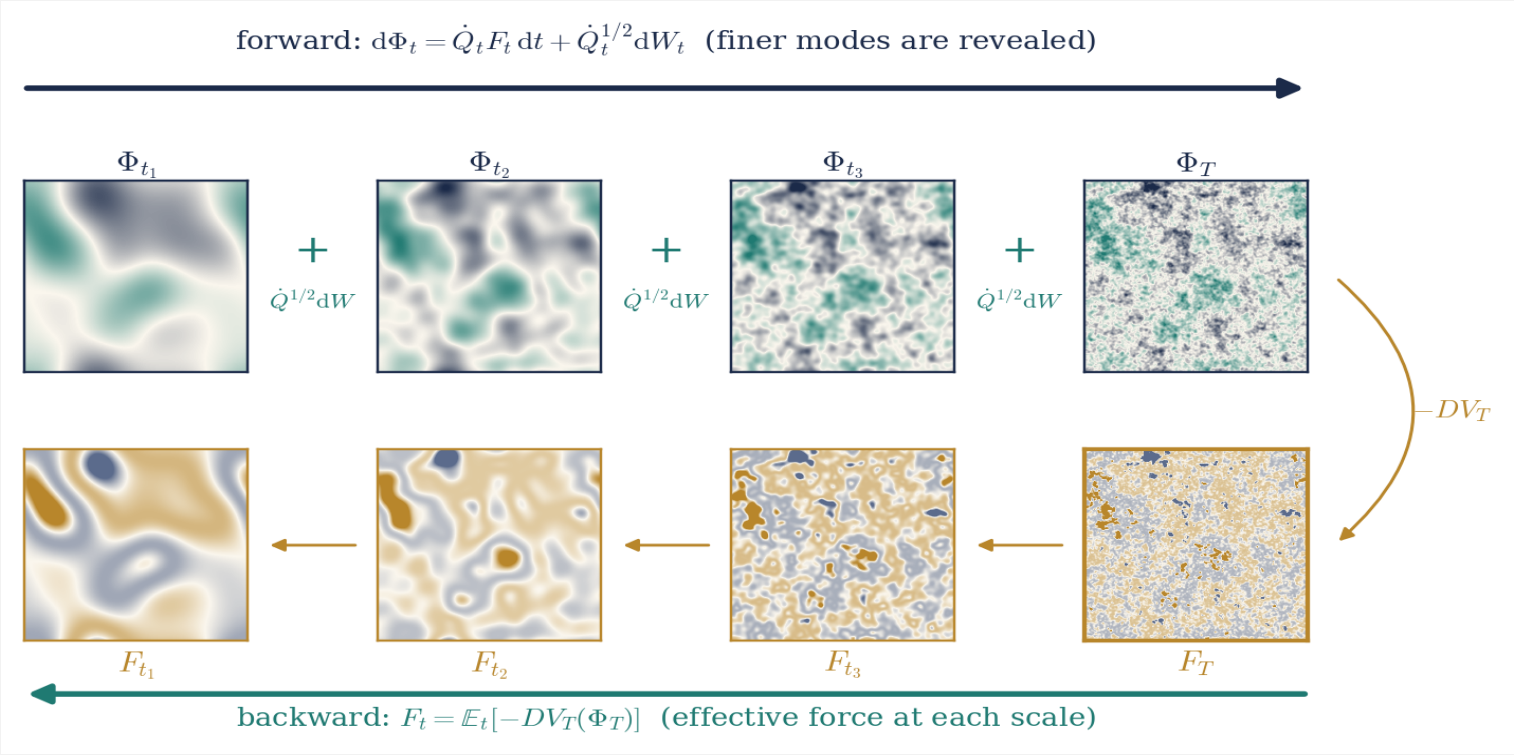
A forward–backward system

Read as an equation for an unknown pair (Φ, F):

$$\Phi_t = \int_0^t \dot{Q}_s F_s \, \mathrm{d}s + \int_0^t \dot{Q}_s^{1/2} \mathrm{d}W_s, \qquad F_t = \mathbb{E}_t\left[-D\, V_T(\Phi_T)\right], \qquad t \in [0,T].$$

- The field is driven **forward** by a force determined **backward** from the terminal field.
- No Polchinski equation needed; $\nu_T = \mathrm{Law}(\Phi_T)$ from the solution.
- **Strategy**: solve with renormalised V_T, estimates uniform in T and volume, take limits.
- Φ is **not** an observable (a semimartingale); observables are built from the noise and from F.

Forward field, backward force



$\mathbb{T}^2$, heat profile, same noise; each panel in its own units. The force is shown to first order in λ: $F_t = -4\lambda H_3(\Phi_t; c_t)$.

The Polchinski equation

Theorem. (Polchinski 1984) (formal)

$$\partial_t V_t = \tfrac{1}{2}\langle D V_t, \dot{Q}_t D V_t\rangle - \tfrac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}(\dot{Q}_t D^2 V_t), \qquad V_T \text{ given.}$$

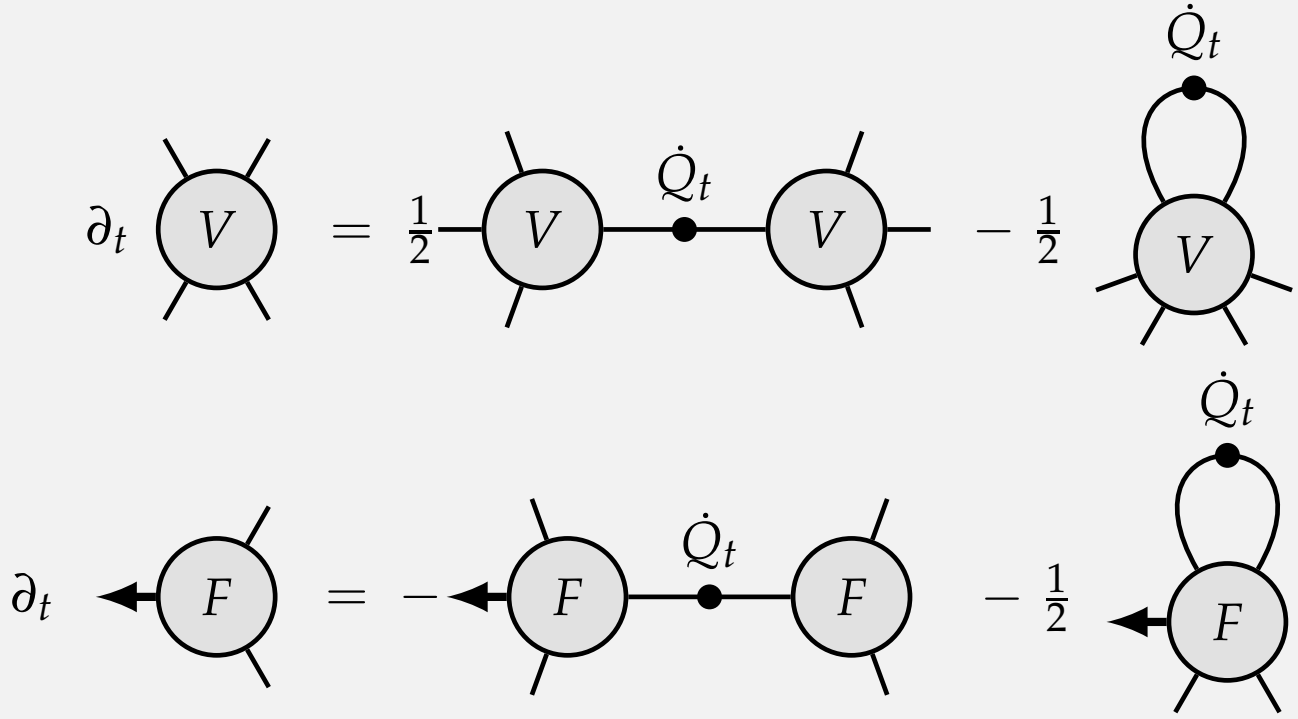
Proof. $u_t = \mathrm{e}^{-V_t} = \mathrm{e}^{\frac{1}{2}\Delta_{Q_T,t}} u_T$, $\Delta_Q = \mathrm{Tr}(Q D^2)$, solves the backward heat equation $\partial_t u_t = -\tfrac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}(\dot{Q}_t D^2 u_t)$. Insert $D^2 u = (D V \otimes D V - D^2 V)\, u$.

Nonlinear term: generates new, nonlocal interactions (**trees**).

Trace term: contracts pairs of fields with the shell covariance $\dot{Q}_t \mathrm{d}t$: **loops**.

A backward Hamilton–Jacobi equation; $u = \mathrm{e}^{-V}$ is a Cole–Hopf transform.

The Polchinski equation in graphs



Blob: derivatives of V_t or of the force. Dotted line: $\dot{Q}_t$. Tree term and loop term; iterating gives the connected Feynman graphs.

The Boué–Dupuis formula

$\mathbb{H}_a$: adapted drifts with $\mathbb{E}\int_0^T \|u_s\|^2 < \infty$; $X^u = X + \int_0^\cdot \dot{Q}_s^{1/2} u_s \, \mathrm{d}s$.

Theorem. (Boué–Dupuis 1998; Polchinski = HJB) (formal)

$$-\log \mathbb{E}_0[\mathrm{e}^{-V_T(X_T)}] = V_0(0) = \inf_{u \in \mathbb{H}_a} \mathbb{E}_0\left[V_T(X_T^u) + \frac{1}{2}\int_0^T \|u_s\|^2 \mathrm{d}s \right].$$

Optimal feedback $u_s^* = -\dot{Q}_s^{1/2} D\, V_s(X_s^{u^*})$, $\mathrm{Law}(X_T^{u^*}) = \nu_T$. *$V_t$ is the* ***value function****; Polchinski is the* ***HJB equation****.*

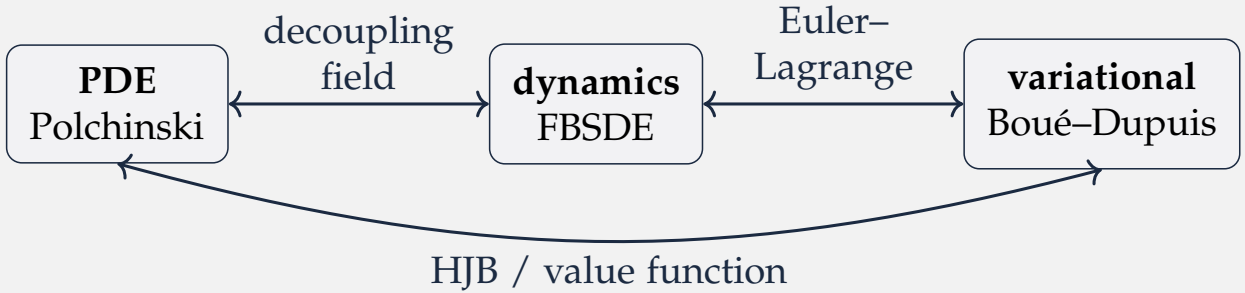
Proof (verification). Itô + Polchinski:

$$\mathbb{E}_0\left[V_T(X_T^u) + \tfrac{1}{2}\int_0^T \|u_t\|^2 \right] = V_0(0) + \tfrac{1}{2}\mathbb{E}_0 \int_0^T \|u_t + \dot{Q}_t^{1/2} D\, V_t(X_t^u)\|^2 \mathrm{d}t.$$

The control problem: PDE, dynamics, variational

Euler–Lagrange. Perturb $u \to u + \varepsilon v$:

$$u_s = -\dot{Q}_s^{1/2}\, \mathbb{E}_s\left[D V_T(X_T^u)\right] = \dot{Q}_s^{1/2} F_s: \quad \text{the FBSDE.}$$



Entropy. $\frac{1}{2}\mathbb{E}_0 \int \|u\|^2 \geqslant \mathsf{Ent}(\mathsf{Law}(X^u)|\mathsf{Law}(X))$: a pathwise lift of the Gibbs principle $-\log Z_T = \inf_\nu \{\int V_T \,\mathrm{d}\nu + \mathsf{Ent}(\nu|\mu^{Q_T})\}$. Useful because adapted drifts can be **built scale by scale**, as functionals of X.

Renormalisation in the variational picture

Generating functional:

$$\mathscr{W}_T(f) = -\log \int \mathrm{e}^{-f} \mathrm{d}\nu_T = \inf_u \mathbb{E}_0 \Big[(f + V_T)(X_T^u) + \frac{1}{2} \int_0^T \|u_s\|^2 \Big] - V_0(0).$$

Bounds uniform in $T \Rightarrow$ tightness, moments, identification of limits.

Φ_3^4. The leading drift $u_s \approx -4\lambda \dot{Q}_s^{1/2} {:}X_s^3{:}$ has **divergent cost**,

$$\tfrac{1}{2}\mathbb{E} \int_0^T \| 4\lambda \dot{Q}_s^{1/2} {:}X_s^3{:} \|^2 \mathrm{d}s = 12\lambda^2 L^3 \int Q_T(z)^4 \, \mathrm{d}z \sim T.$$

Change variables $u = -4\lambda \dot{Q}^{1/2} {:}X^3{:} + r$, then paracontrolled changes of variables: the singular terms become explicit polynomials in Wick powers of X, **cancelled by the counterterms**, and the remainder is coercive. Uniform control in Besov/paracontrolled norms = construction of Φ_3^4. Barashkov–Gubinelli, Duke 2020; EJP 2021

Pontryagin's maximum principle

Minimise $J(u) = g(x_T) + \int_t^T \ell(x_s, u_s)\,\mathrm{d}s$ subject to $\dot{x} = b(x,u)$, $x_t = x$. **Hamiltonian:**

$$H(x,p,u) = \langle p, b(x,u)\rangle - \ell(x,u).$$

Theorem. (Pontryagin) *Along an optimal pair there is a* ***costate*** p *with*

$$\dot{x} = \partial_p H, \qquad \dot{p} = -\partial_x H, \qquad p_T = -Dg(x_T), \qquad u \in \arg\max H(x,p,\cdot).$$

- State forward, costate backward: a **two-point boundary problem**.
- The costate is the Lagrange multiplier of the constraint $\dot{x} = b$; an optimal control is a critical point of the Hamiltonian.
- Next: why this holds, and what p is.

Pontryagin–Boltyanskii–Gamkrelidze–Mishchenko 1962.

Pontryagin: first variation and HJB

First variation. Perturb $u \to u + \varepsilon v$; the state varies by $\xi = \partial_\varepsilon x$,

$$\dot{\xi} = \partial_x b\, \xi + \partial_u b\, v, \qquad \xi_t = 0.$$

The costate equation $\dot{p} = -\partial_x H$ is exactly what makes

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}s}\langle p, \xi\rangle = \langle \partial_x \ell, \xi\rangle + \langle p, \partial_u b\, v\rangle.$$

Integrating, with $p_T = -Dg(x_T)$:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}\varepsilon} J(u + \varepsilon v)|_{\varepsilon=0} = -\int_t^T \langle \partial_u H(x_s, p_s, u_s), v_s\rangle \,\mathrm{d}s.$$

HJB. Dynamic programming over $[t, t + \mathrm{d}t]$:

$$V(t,x) = \min_u \left[\, \ell\, \mathrm{d}t + V(t + \mathrm{d}t, x + b\, \mathrm{d}t)\,\right] \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \partial_t V = H_*(x, -DV), \quad H_* = \max_u H.$$

Hamilton's equations for H_* are its characteristics, and along them $p_s = -DV(s, x_s)$: the costate is the force the future exerts on the present.

The Hamiltonian of the field

State = field, $b = \dot{Q}_s^{1/2} u$, $\ell = \frac{1}{2}\|u\|^2$, $g = V_T$. H is maximised at $u = \dot{Q}_s^{1/2} p$:

$$H_*(p) = \frac{1}{2}\langle p, \dot{Q}_s p\rangle:$$

a free particle with mass matrix $\dot{Q}_s^{-1}$, and no dependence on the state x.

- **Without noise:** $\dot{p} = 0$, $\dot{x} = \dot{Q}p$: the **shear** Σ_t: $(x,p) \mapsto (x + S_t p, p)$, with $S_t := Q_T - Q_t$ the covariance still unresolved. All interaction is in $p = -D V_T(x + S_t p)$: **trees**. HJB = Polchinski without the trace.
- **With noise** (Bismut 1973, Peng 1990): the costate solves a BSDE

$$\mathrm{d}p_s = -\partial_x H \,\mathrm{d}s + \Upsilon_s \,\mathrm{d}W_s,$$

  with $\Upsilon \,\mathrm{d}W$ the price of adaptedness. Here $\partial_x H = 0$: the costate is a **martingale**, $p_t = -D V_t(X_t) = F_t$.
- The Itô term turns HJB into **Polchinski**: quadratic part = trees, trace term = loops.

The FBSDE is the stochastic Hamiltonian system: field = state, force = costate.

State and costate

Here $\dot{S}_t = -\dot{Q}_t$, $S_T = 0$. Optimal control $u_t = \dot{Q}_t^{1/2} p_t$, with costate $p_t = F_t$:

$$\mathrm{d}F_t = \mathrm{Y}_t \,\mathrm{d}W_t, \qquad \mathrm{Y}_t = DF_t(\Phi_t)\,\dot{Q}_t^{1/2}.$$

- $F_t(\cdot)$ is the **decoupling field**, $F_t = F_t(\Phi_t)$; Burgers is its quasilinear PDE, and Y the martingale representation integrand of the costate.
- In Burgers: transport term $-DF\,[\dot{Q}\,F]$ ← drift of the state; Itô term $-\frac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}(\dot{Q}\,D^2F)$ ← noise.
- The shear Σ_t is the flow of the transport part: its characteristics.

Filtering: measuring the field

Assume all covariance operators are functions of A. Let $\mathscr{R}_t = S_t^{-1} - Q_T^{-1}$, and $j_t = S_t^{-1}\Phi_t$. By the Gaussian bridge,

$$j_t = \mathscr{R}_t \Phi_T + N_t, \quad \mathbb{E}[N_s \otimes N_t] = \mathscr{R}_{s\wedge t}, \quad N \text{ independent of } \Phi_T:$$

a noisy measurement of the terminal field, whose signal-to-noise ratio is the **regulator**. Let $\mathscr{K}_t(j) = \log \int \mathrm{e}^{\langle j,y\rangle - \frac{1}{2}\langle y, \mathscr{R}_t y\rangle} \nu_T(\mathrm{d}y)$.

- $\mu_t^{\Phi_t}$ is the **Bayesian posterior**; $\psi_t = \mathbb{E}_t \Phi_T = D\mathscr{K}_t(j_t)$ and $\mathrm{Cov}_t = D^2\mathscr{K}_t(j_t)$.
- W is the **innovation**: $\mathrm{d}j_t = \dot{\mathscr{R}}_t \psi_t \,\mathrm{d}t + \dot{\mathscr{R}}_t^{1/2}\,\mathrm{d}W_t$ and $\mathrm{d}\psi_t = \mathrm{Cov}_t \dot{\mathscr{R}}_t^{1/2}\,\mathrm{d}W_t$.
- $\partial_t \mathscr{K} + \frac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}(\dot{\mathscr{R}} D^2\mathscr{K}) + \frac{1}{2}\langle D\mathscr{K}, \dot{\mathscr{R}} D\mathscr{K}\rangle = 0$: Polchinski in the variable j.

Eldan's basic scheme is the profile with $\mathscr{R}_t = t$: the profile of Lectures 5–6.

Where the three views meet

	Renormalisation	Control	Filtering
Φ_t	field at resolution t	state	posterior mean, Gaussian prior: $S_t j_t$
F_t	effective force	costate	posterior mean of the terminal force
W	fresh fluctuation of the shell	noise of the controlled field	innovation
S_t	unresolved covariance	free motion from t to T	posterior covariance, Gaussian prior
$\psi_t = \Phi_t + S_t F_t$	mean of the conditional law	terminal state, free prediction	posterior mean
Cov_t	covariance of the conditional law	$S_t - S_t D^2 V_t S_t$	posterior covariance
V_t	effective potential	value function	$\frac{1}{2}\langle x, S_t^{-1} x\rangle - \mathcal{H}_t(S_t^{-1} x) + f(t)$

$\psi_t - \Phi_t = S_t F_t$: **the force is what the interaction adds to the estimate**, in units of the free propagator S_t, and Cov_t replaces S_t as the propagator.

Closed versus local

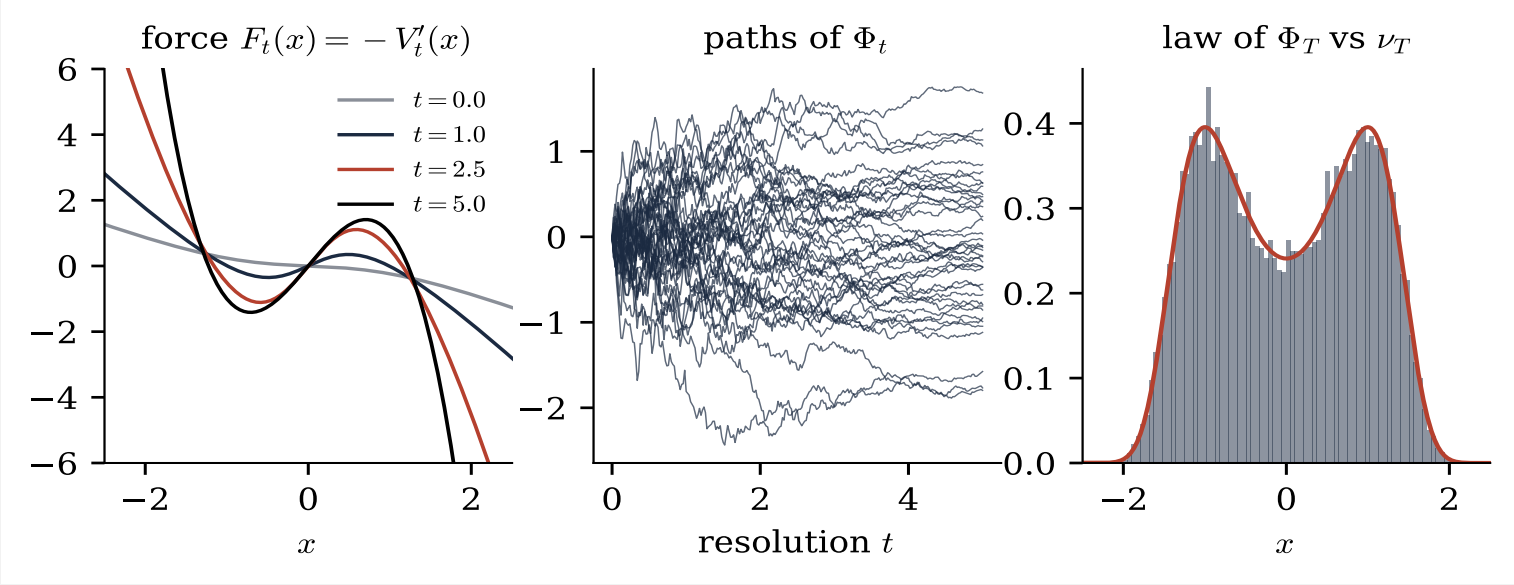
At finite T the force is a **closed** observable, $F_t = \mathbb{E}_t[F_T]$, and for Φ^4 it is **local**:

$$F_T(x) = -4\lambda H_3(\Phi_T(x); c_T) - 2\gamma_T H_1(\Phi_T(x); c_T).$$

As $T \to \infty$

F should converge **as an observable**. In $d = 2$ it is closed, $F_\infty = -4\lambda{:}\Phi^3_\infty{:}$. In $d = 3$ a closed limit $F_t = \mathbb{E}_t F_\infty$ would let the DS identity pass to $t \to \infty$, and conditioning on $\sigma(\Phi_\infty)$ would give an integrable logarithmic derivative of Φ^4_3 as a function of the field: not expected (Albeverio–Liang–Zegarlinski 2006: the regularised ones do not converge in L^2). Locality of the limiting force is the crux of the construction.

Zero dimensions



$Q_t = 1 - \mathrm{e}^{-t}$, $T = 5$, $V_T(x) = \frac{1}{2}x^4 - \frac{3}{2}x^2$. Left: $F_t = -V_t'$, almost linear at low resolution, double well as $t \to T$. Centre: FBSDE paths split between the wells (stochastic localisation). Right: histogram of Φ_T vs. the density of ν_T.

Force coordinates and potentials

Lecture 4

The force: a Burgers equation

Differentiating Polchinski, $F_t = -D V_t$ solves the backward viscous **Burgers equation**

$$\partial_t F_t = -D F_t[\dot{Q}_t F_t] - \tfrac{1}{2}\mathsf{Tr}(\dot{Q}_t D^2 F_t), \qquad F_T = -D V_T.$$

- Cole–Hopf $F = D\log u$ linearises it ($u = \mathrm{e}^{-V}$ solves a heat equation).
- Uses only the force: **intensive**, while V_t is extensive ($\sim$ volume). Matters in infinite volume.
- Flows for different covariances commute when DF is symmetric, i.e. F a gradient. Non-gradient forces (general Wilson–Itô diffusions): curvature.

Removing the predictable drift: the forecast

Proposition. (formal) *The conditional mean of the terminal field is*

$$\psi_t := \mathbb{E}_t[\Phi_T] = \Phi_t + S_t F_t, \qquad (\psi_t, F_t) = \Sigma_t(\Phi_t, F_t),$$

a martingale with $\mathrm{d}\psi_t = \dot{Q}_t^{1/2}\mathrm{d}W_t + S_t\,\mathrm{d}F_t = (1 + S_t D F_t(\Phi_t))\,\dot{Q}_t^{1/2}\mathrm{d}W_t$.

Proof. F martingale $\Rightarrow \mathbb{E}_t \int_t^T \dot{Q}_s F_s\,\mathrm{d}s = S_t F_t$. In the differential, $\dot{Q}_t F_t\,\mathrm{d}t$ cancels with $\dot{S}_t F_t\,\mathrm{d}t$.

- $\Phi_t = \psi_t - S_t F_t$: a martingale (the **field observable**) minus the drift still expected on the unresolved scales.
- Noise of ψ: fresh shell fluctuation + **revision of the forecast**. The forward–backward coupling moves from the drift to the volatility.

ψ is the **interaction picture** w.r.t. the classical dynamics.

The FBSDE in forecast coordinates

Invert $x \mapsto \psi = x + S_t F_t(x)$: $x = \psi + S_t \mathscr{F}_t(\psi)$, $\mathscr{F}_t(\psi) := -F_t(x)$. Response and regulator:

$$H_t(\psi) = (S_t^{-1} + D\,\mathscr{F}_t(\psi))^{-1}, \qquad \mathscr{R}_t = S_t^{-1} - Q_T^{-1}, \qquad \dot{\mathscr{R}}_t = S_t^{-1}\,\dot{Q}_t\,S_t^{-1} \geqslant 0.$$

Theorem. (formal)

$$\mathrm{d}\psi_t = H_t(\psi_t)\; S_t^{-1}\,\dot{Q}_t^{1/2}\,\mathrm{d}W_t, \qquad \mathscr{F}_t(\psi_t) = \mathbb{E}_t\big[D\,V_T(\psi_T)\big],$$

$\psi_T = \Phi_T$. ***No drift***; *covariance* $\mathscr{C}_t = H_t\,\dot{\mathscr{R}}_t\,H_t^*$. *The decoupling field solves the* ***pure diffusion*** *equation*

$$\partial_t\,\mathscr{F}_t + \frac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}(\mathscr{C}_t\,D^2\,\mathscr{F}_t) = 0, \qquad \mathscr{F}_T = D\,V_T.$$

Proof. $1 + S_t D F_t = H_t S_t^{-1}$; $\mathscr{F}_t(\psi_t)$ is a martingale and ψ has no drift: Itô.

What the change of coordinates did

Compare with Burgers:

$$\underbrace{\partial_t F = -DF\,[\dot{Q}F] - \tfrac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}(\dot{Q}D^2F)}_{\text{field coordinate}} \quad \longrightarrow \quad \underbrace{\partial_t \mathscr{F} = -\tfrac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}(\mathscr{C}\ D^2\mathscr{F})}_{\text{forecast coordinate}}$$

- The transport term is **absorbed exactly**: dropping the Itô term, $\mathscr{F}_t = DV_T$ does not move. All **trees** live in the coordinate change $x = \psi + S_t\mathscr{F}_t(\psi)$.
- **Loops** come only from the quadratic variation $\mathscr{C}_t$ of the forecast; the nonlinearity has moved into its field dependence.
- No gradient structure, no Gaussian convolution used: valid for any FBSDE with a Markov martingale force, whenever the coordinate change is invertible.

Conditional moments

Proposition. (formal) *If* $F_t = -D V_t$, *then*

$$H_t(\psi_t) = \mathrm{Cov}_t := \mathrm{Cov}^{\mathbb{P}}(\Phi_T \mid \Phi_t) = S_t - S_t D^2 V_t(\Phi_t)\, S_t.$$

So $H_t > 0$, $1 + S_t D F_t$ *is always invertible, and* $H_t \leqslant S_t$ *for convex* V_T *(Brascamp–Lieb).*

The forecast coordinates are the first two conditional moments of the stochastic localisation: $(\psi_t, \mathrm{Cov}_t) = (\mathbb{E}[\Phi_T \mid \Phi_t], \mathrm{Cov}(\Phi_T \mid \Phi_t))$. The second moment

$$\mathbb{E}_t[\Phi_T \otimes \Phi_T] = \psi_t \otimes \psi_t + \mathrm{Cov}_t$$

is a martingale, hence

$$\mathrm{d}\langle \psi, \psi \rangle_t = \mathrm{Cov}_t \dot{\mathscr{R}}_t \mathrm{Cov}_t \,\mathrm{d}t, \qquad \mathrm{dCov}_t = -\mathrm{Cov}_t \dot{\mathscr{R}}_t \mathrm{Cov}_t \,\mathrm{d}t + \mathrm{d}(\text{mart.}).$$

Gaussian reference: $S_t \dot{\mathscr{R}}_t S_t = \dot{Q}_t$.

Brascamp–Lieb bounds on the conditional covariance

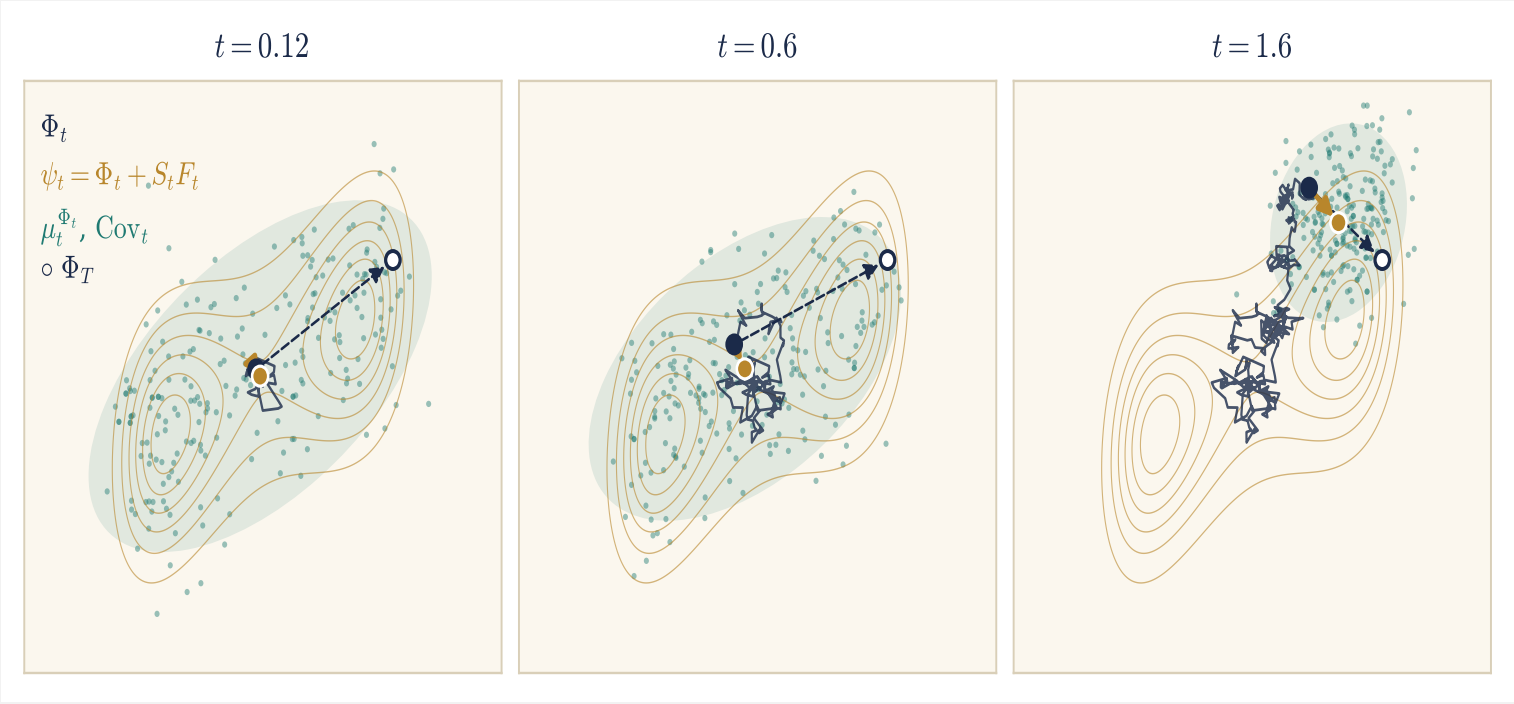
Conditional law $\mu_t^\phi \propto \mathrm{e}^{-\mathcal{U}}$, $D^2\mathcal{U} = S_t^{-1} + D^2 V_T$. Then

$$(\mathbb{E}_t[S_t^{-1} + D^2 V_T])^{-1} \leqslant \mathrm{Cov}_t \leqslant \mathbb{E}_t[(S_t^{-1} + D^2 V_T)^{-1}].$$

- **Lower:** Cramér–Rao, no convexity needed: $\mathbb{E}[(y-m)\otimes D\,\mathcal{U}] = 1$ and Cauchy–Schwarz.
- **Upper:** Brascamp–Lieb (1976), for $D^2\mathcal{U} > 0$: $\mathrm{Var}(f) \leqslant \mathbb{E}\langle Df, (D^2\mathcal{U})^{-1} Df\rangle$.
- Equal for quadratic V_T. Via $\mathrm{Cov}_t = S_t - S_t D^2 V_t S_t$: two-sided bounds on $D^2 V_t$, i.e. on the Wetterich propagator H_t.
- V_T convex $\Rightarrow \mathrm{Cov}_t \leqslant S_t$, $D^2 V_t \geqslant 0$: convexity propagates along Polchinski. $D^2 V_T \geqslant \kappa \Rightarrow \mathrm{Cov}_t \leqslant (S_t^{-1} + \kappa)^{-1}$.

Φ_3^4: Wick ordering gives V_T the curvature $-12\lambda c_T + 2\gamma_T \to -\infty$ at $\varphi = 0$ (already for Φ_2^4). The upper bound is lost, the conditional law may spread over several wells: the **large-field problem** (clipping and global coercivity, Lecture 5).

Stochastic localisation: a picture



Two-component field, V_T a tilted double well (contours: ν_T). Path Φ_t, forecast $\psi_t = \Phi_t + S_t F_t$, conditional law $\mu_t^{\Phi_t}$ and 2σ ellipse of Cov_t; open circle: Φ_T. The conditional law localises on one well.

Phase space and Lagrangian graphs

Phase space of pairs (field, force) $(x,p) \in \mathbb{R}^n \times \mathbb{R}^n$, with the symplectic form

$$\omega = \sum_i \mathrm{d}x_i \wedge \mathrm{d}p_i.$$

- L (dimension n) is **Lagrangian** if $\omega|_L = 0$.
- A graph $p = F(x)$ is Lagrangian $\Leftrightarrow$ DF symmetric $\Leftrightarrow$ F is a gradient. **Gradient sector = Lagrangian graphs.**
- Symplectic maps send Lagrangian submanifolds to Lagrangian ones. The shear $\Sigma_t(x,p) = (x + S_t p, p)$ is symplectic since S_t is symmetric: $\Sigma_t^* \omega = \omega + \sum S_{ij}\, \mathrm{d}p_j \wedge \mathrm{d}p_i = \omega$.

So Σ_t maps the graph of $F_t = -DV_t$ to a Lagrangian submanifold; if it is a graph over the forecast ψ, it is the graph of a gradient.

The free action generates the shear

The cheapest way to reach ψ at T from x at t, without interaction, costs the **free action**

$$\mathscr{A}_t(x,\psi) = \frac{1}{2}\langle \psi - x, S_t^{-1}(\psi - x)\rangle, \quad p = S_t^{-1}(\psi - x) \text{ constant.}$$

- $D_x\mathscr{A}_t = -p$, $D_\psi\mathscr{A}_t = p$: so $\mathscr{A}_t$ is the **generating function** of the shear Σ_t.
- $\partial_t\mathscr{A}_t = \frac{1}{2}\langle D_x\mathscr{A}_t, \dot{Q}_t D_x\mathscr{A}_t\rangle$: a complete integral of the noiseless Polchinski equation.
- Jacobi: in the new coordinates the Hamiltonian vanishes, and ψ, p are constants of motion.

(ψ_t, F_t) are the Jacobi coordinates of the free Hamiltonian of the field. With noise, the constants of motion become **martingales**.

The gradient sector

$F_t = -D V_t$. The map $x \mapsto x + S_t F_t(x)$ is S_t times the gradient of

$$\frac{1}{2}\langle x, S_t^{-1} x\rangle - V_t(x), \qquad \text{with Hessian } S_t^{-1}\mathrm{Cov}_t S_t^{-1} > 0,$$

so it is injective: the image of the graph of F_t is a graph over ψ, that of $-\mathscr{F}_t$ with

$$\mathscr{F}_t = D\Gamma_t, \qquad H_t = (S_t^{-1} + D^2\Gamma_t)^{-1}, \qquad \Gamma_T = V_T.$$

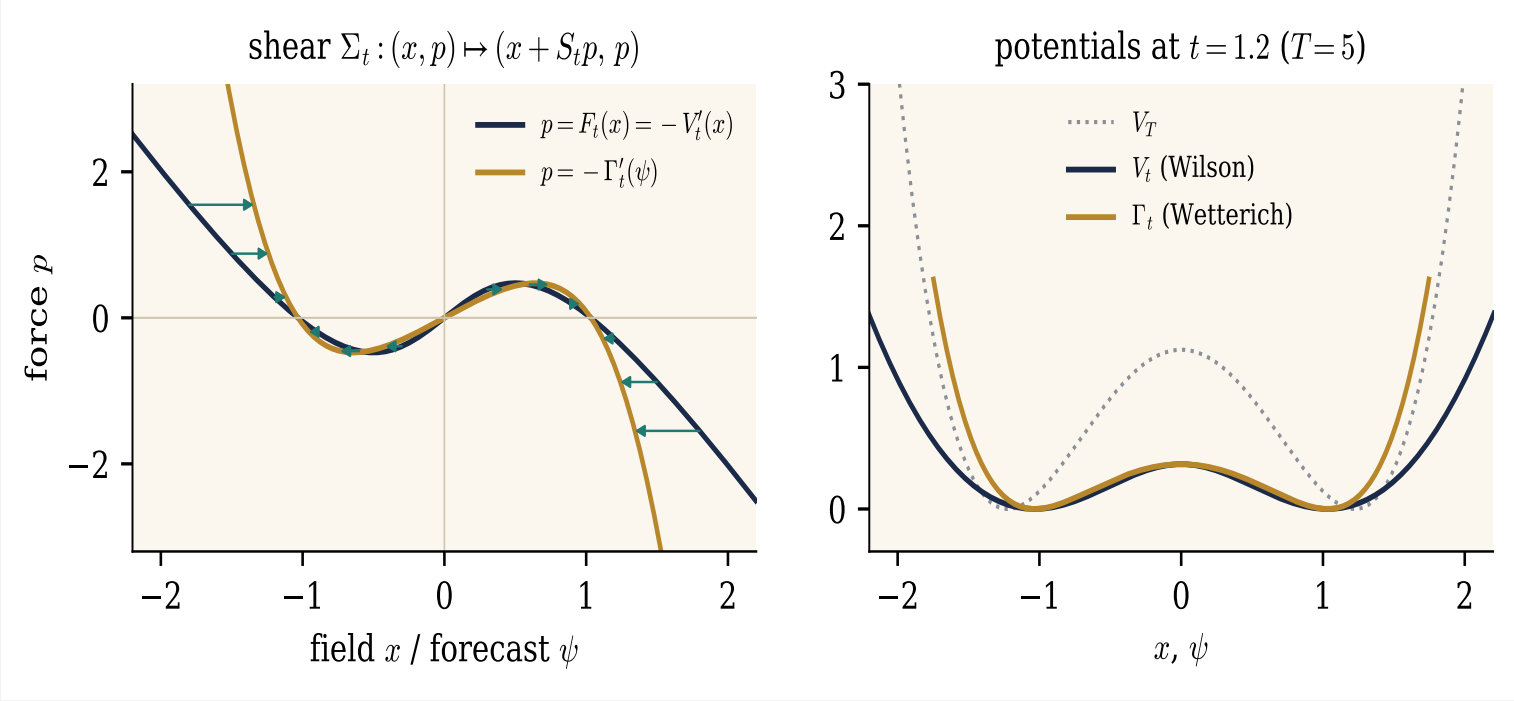
Generating function: the **Moreau transform**

$$V_t(x) = \inf_{\psi}\left\{\Gamma_t(\psi) + \tfrac{1}{2}\langle x-\psi, S_t^{-1}(x-\psi)\rangle\right\},$$

optimality: $x = \psi + S_t D\Gamma_t(\psi)$, $D V_t(x) = D\Gamma_t(\psi)$.

No convexity of V_T or Γ_t is used: only $S_t^{-1} + D^2\Gamma_t = \mathrm{Cov}_t^{-1} > 0$. Without noise, caustics and shocks.

The shear in zero dimensions



Left: Σ_t maps the graph of $F_t = -V_t'$ to the graph of $-\Gamma_t'$ over the forecast.
Right: V_T, V_t and Γ_t ($t = 1.2$, $T = 5$).

The Wetterich equation

Theorem. (formal)

$$\partial_t \Gamma_t = \frac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}\big[\dot{\mathscr{R}}_t\,((S_t^{-1} + D^2\Gamma_t)^{-1} - S_t)\big], \qquad \Gamma_T = V_T.$$

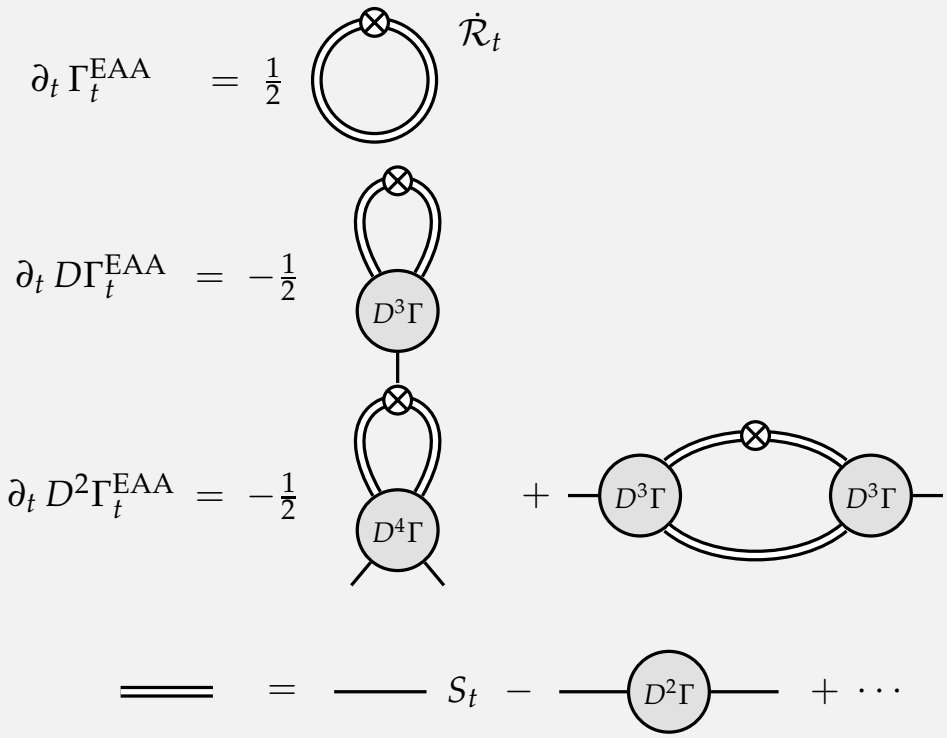
Equivalently, for the ***effective average action*** $\Gamma_t^{\mathsf{EAA}} = \Gamma_t + \frac{1}{2}\langle \psi, Q_T^{-1}\psi\rangle$,

$$\partial_t \Gamma_t^{\mathsf{EAA}} = \frac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}\big[\dot{\mathscr{R}}_t\,(D^2\Gamma_t^{\mathsf{EAA}} + \mathscr{R}_t)^{-1}\big] + c(t),$$

from the bare action ($t = T$, $\mathscr{R}_T = \infty$) to the 1PI effective action of ν_T ($t = 0$, $\mathscr{R}_0 = 0$).

Proof. $D_v \mathrm{Tr}(\dot{\mathscr{R}} H) = -\mathrm{Tr}(\mathscr{C}\, D^2\mathscr{F})[v]$ by symmetry of $D^3\Gamma$, so the force equation reads $D\left(\partial_t\Gamma - \frac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}(\dot{\mathscr{R}} H)\right) = 0$. The constant: envelope theorem + Polchinski.

The Wetterich equation in graphs



Double line: full response. Cross: $\dot{\mathcal{R}}_t$. Exactly one loop: the Legendre transform has absorbed the tree term.

Wetterich = the backward half of the FBSDE

Every object in the Wetterich equation is an observable of the Polchinski process.

Wetterich	FBSDE
field argument ψ	forecast $\psi_t = \mathbb{E}_t[\Phi_T]$
$D\Gamma_t(\psi_t)$	minus the costate, $\mathbb{E}_t[D V_T(\Phi_T)]$
propagator $(D^2\Gamma_t^{\mathsf{EAA}} + \mathscr{R}_t)^{-1}$	conditional covariance Cov_t
regulator $\mathscr{R}_t = S_t^{-1} - Q_T^{-1}$	shell precision minus prior precision
$\partial_t \Gamma_t$	$\frac{1}{2}\mathsf{Tr}[\dot{\mathscr{R}}_t(\mathsf{Cov}_t - S_t)]$

Driven by **interacting minus free** conditional covariance; **one-loop exact**, with the full propagator; in the Gaussian case only the constant flows. Wetterich 1993; Morris 1994; Berges–Tetradis–Wetterich 2002

One graph, three generators

Value function. At the optimal forecast, $V_t(x) = \Gamma_t(\psi) + \mathscr{A}_t(x, \psi)$: the cost attached to the forecast plus the cost of reaching it by free motion. This transports the generating function along Σ_t:

$$\mathrm{d}\, V_t = \langle D\Gamma_t, \mathrm{d}\psi \rangle + \langle p, \mathrm{d}\psi \rangle - \langle p, \mathrm{d}x \rangle = -\langle F_t, \mathrm{d}x \rangle.$$

Legendre. With $\mathscr{H}_t(S_t^{-1}x) = \frac{1}{2}\langle x, S_t^{-1}x \rangle - V_t(x)$ up to a function of t,

$$\mathscr{H}_t^*(\psi) = \Gamma_t(\psi) + \frac{1}{2}\langle \psi, S_t^{-1}\psi \rangle.$$

- V_t in the field x; $\mathscr{H}_t$ in the measurement $j = S_t^{-1}x$; Γ_t in the forecast ψ.
- Polchinski is the Hamilton–Jacobi equation of $\mathscr{H}$; Wetterich is its Legendre dual. The regulator is the information gained.

The regulator of the heat profile

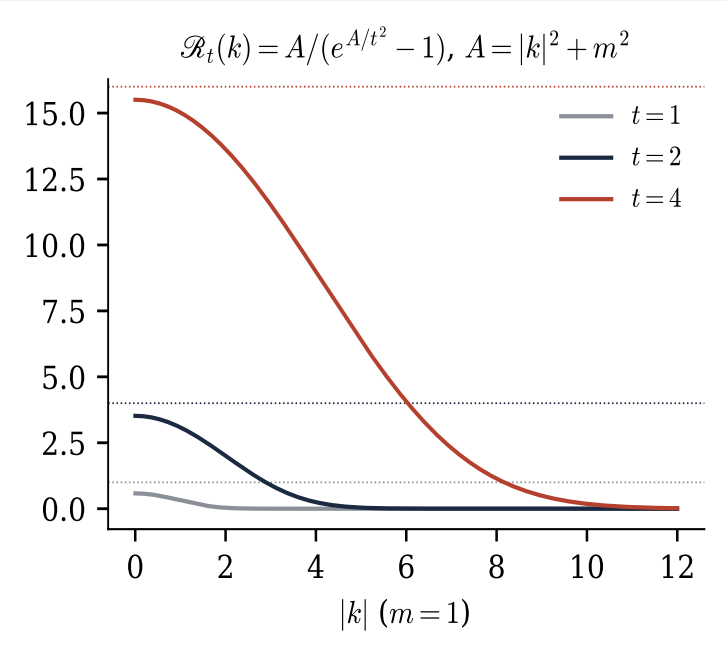
For $T=\infty$, $S_t = C\,(1-\mathrm{e}^{-A/t^2})$ and

$$\mathscr{R}_t = \frac{A}{\mathrm{e}^{A/t^2}-1}.$$

- $\approx t^2$ (a mass term) on the modes $|k| \ll t$;
- exponentially small on $|k| \gg t$.

The **exponential regulator** of the functional RG.

Other profiles give other regulators, e.g. the mass regulator $\mathscr{R}_t = t^2$.



Γ as a rate function

At $t=0$: the 1PI effective action of ν_T (Jona-Lasinio 1964),

$$\Gamma_0^{\mathsf{EAA}}(\psi) = V_0(0) + \sup_j \left\{ \langle j, \psi \rangle - \log \int \mathrm{e}^{\langle j, \varphi \rangle} \, \mathrm{d}\nu_T \right\}.$$

- **Cramér**: the mean of N independent samples is $\approx\psi$ with probability $\approx \mathrm{e}^{-N(\Gamma_0^{\mathsf{EAA}}(\psi) - V_0(0))}$: a **large-deviation rate function**.
- Convex even when V_T is not; minimal at the mean; Hessian there $=$ inverse covariance.
- Formally, the same for the field averaged over a large volume: Γ per unit volume (the effective potential of QFT, not V_t) is the rate function of the magnetisation; flat parts may appear (Maxwell).
- The renormalisation group as a probabilistic object: limit theorems for strongly dependent variables.

Jona-Lasinio, Nuovo Cimento 1964; Nuovo Cimento B 1975; Phys. Rep. 2001.

Variational meaning and the tree level

Constrained free energy. Gibbs variational principle for the conditional law:

$$\Gamma_t(\psi) = \inf\left\{\int V_T \,\mathrm{d}\nu + \mathsf{Ent}(\nu \,|\, \mu^{S_t}(\cdot - \psi)) \colon \int \varphi \,\mathrm{d}\nu = \psi\right\}:$$

the free energy of the unresolved shell, **constrained to the forecast**. V_t is the value function; Γ_t is its Moreau transform.

Tree level. Drop the Itô term: $\Gamma_t = V_T$, and the Moreau transform becomes the **Hopf–Lax formula**

$$V_t^{\mathsf{tree}}(x) = \inf_y \left\{ V_T(y) + \tfrac{1}{2}\langle y - x, S_t^{-1}(y-x)\rangle \right\},$$

which solves $\partial_t V = \frac{1}{2}\langle DV, \dot{Q} DV\rangle$: the saddle point of the Gaussian convolution. The minimiser solves the classical field equation $S_t^{-1}(y-x) + DV_T(y) = 0$ in the shell $[t,T]$; expanding in V_T gives exactly the tree diagrams.

Observables and field equations

Lecture 4

Observables of the interacting theory

For G a functional of the terminal field, $O_t = \mathbb{E}_t^{\mathbb{P}}[G(\Phi_T)] = G_t(\Phi_t)$, $G_t(\phi) = \mu_t^{\phi}(G)$, and

$$\partial_t G_t + \tfrac{1}{2}\mathsf{Tr}(\dot{Q}_t D^2 G_t) - \langle \dot{Q}_t D V_t, D G_t \rangle = 0, \qquad G_T = G:$$

the backward Kolmogorov equation, a Doob transform of the Gaussian heat equation. Any solution gives an observable, closed at finite T, not necessarily as $T \to \infty$. The force is $G = -D V_T$.

Tangent observables. V_T^{θ} depending on a coupling, $U_t = \partial_\theta V_t^{\theta}$:

$$U_t(\Phi_t) = \mathbb{E}_t^{\theta}[\partial_\theta V_T^{\theta}(\Phi_T)], \qquad \partial_\theta \mathbb{E}^{\nu_T^{\theta}}[G] = -\mathsf{Cov}^{\nu_T^{\theta}}(G, \partial_\theta V_T^{\theta}).$$

E.g. the running $:\varphi^4:$: for $\theta = \lambda$: observables **conjugate to the coordinates of theory space**.

Dyson–Schwinger equations at every scale

All operators are functions of A (so they commute); $K = Q_T^{-1}$, $J_t = K Q_t$ (heat profile: a heat semigroup, $\to e^{-A/t^2}$).

The noise observable is the **filtered measurement noise**: $\eta_t = K\Phi_t - J_t F_t = j_t - \mathscr{R}_t \psi_t = \mathbb{E}_t N_t$.

Theorem. (formal) *The **noise observable** $\eta_t = K\Phi_t - J_t F_t$ is a centred martingale,* $\mathrm{d}\eta_t = K\dot{Q}_t^{1/2}\mathrm{d}W_t^{\mathbb{P}} - J_t\,\mathrm{d}F_t$, *and*

$$\mathbb{E}^{\mathbb{P}}\left[D_{J_t h} G(\Phi_t)\right] = \mathbb{E}^{\mathbb{P}}\left[G(\Phi_t)\,\langle h, K\Phi_t - J_t F_t\rangle\right].$$

At $t = T$: the DS equation $\mathbb{E}^{\nu_T}[D_h G] = \mathbb{E}^{\nu_T}[G\langle h, K\varphi + D V_T\rangle]$.

Proof. $\dot{J}_t = K\dot{Q}_t$: drifts cancel. IBP for μ^{Q_t} in direction $J_t h$, using $\Phi_t \sim \nu_t$.

The field equation at resolution t

As $T \to \infty$, $K \to A$, and $\eta_t = K\Phi_t - J_t F_t$ becomes

$$A\,\Phi_t = A\,Q_t\,F_t + \eta_t \qquad (A\,Q_t = \mathrm{e}^{-A/t^2} \text{ for the heat profile}):$$

the Euclidean field equation $A\,\varphi = -V'(\varphi) + \text{noise}$, **seen at resolution t**. No products of distributions: the nonlinearity enters only through the force **observable**, smeared at scale $1/t$. For Φ^4_3, with F_t in the role of the renormalised cube, $t \to \infty$ corresponds to the renormalised DS equation (Gubinelli–Hofmanová 2021).

Compare: stochastic quantisation (Lecture 3)

There the field equation is imposed in an **auxiliary time**; here it holds at **each resolution**, and the auxiliary parameter is the resolution itself.

Conditioning an SPDE solution on a scale filtration gives identities of the same shape but with a different noise: the martingale $J_t\,\mathrm{d}F_t$ in $\mathrm{d}\eta_t$ is essential.

The noise is sub-Gaussian

η_t is, through J_t, the score of the law of Φ_t: $\eta_t = -J_t D \log p_t(\Phi_t)$. Given Φ_T, the interacting field is still the Gaussian bridge:

$$\Phi_t = J_t \Phi_T + \zeta_t, \quad \zeta_t \sim N(0, Q_t(1-J_t)) \quad \Rightarrow \quad \eta_t = \mathbb{E}\big[J_t (Q_t(1-J_t))^{-1} \zeta_t | \Phi_t\big].$$

Proposition. *η_t is dominated in convex order by $N(0, \mathscr{R}_t)$, with $\mathscr{R}_t = S_t^{-1} - Q_T^{-1}$ the **Wetterich regulator**; in particular*

$$\mathbb{E}\, \mathrm{e}^{u\langle h, \eta_t\rangle} \leqslant \exp\left(\frac{u^2}{2}\langle h, \mathscr{R}_t h\rangle\right),$$

uniformly in the interaction, with no convexity (conditional Jensen).

- Heat profile, $T = \infty$ (finite spatial cutoff): $\mathscr{R}_t = A/(\mathrm{e}^{A/t^2} - 1) \leqslant t^2$; $\mathscr{R}_t \leqslant \frac{4}{3} t^2$ for $T \geqslant 2t$.
- With $\mathrm{d}F = \Upsilon \,\mathrm{d}W$ and Itô: $\mathbb{E}\int_0^t \|\Upsilon_s^* J_s h\|^2 \,\mathrm{d}s \leqslant 2\,(1+\mathrm{e}^{-1})\, t^2 \|h\|^2$: a smoothed derivative of the force, without the terminal force.
- Φ^4_3: the noise in $A\Phi_t = A Q_t F_t + \eta_t$ is controlled a priori; what remains is coercivity of the renormalised force.

How rough is the noise?

Spectral densities, heat profile, $T=\infty$, $A=|k|^2+m^2$:

white noise	GFF	free noise $A X_t$	bound $\mathscr{R}_t$
1	A^{-1}	$A\,\mathrm{e}^{-A/t^2}$	$\dfrac{A}{\mathrm{e}^{A/t^2}-1}$

- $\mathscr{R}_t \leqslant t^2 \mathrm{e}^{-A/2t^2}$: at resolution t, $\eta_t \lesssim t \times$ white noise smoothed at scale $1/t$, so $\eta_t(x) = O(t^{1+d/2})$.
- At scale $1/t$ this is the size of regularity $-1-d/2$ ($-5/2$ in $d=3$): one derivative rougher than white noise, like the free noise $A^{1/2}\xi$, **whatever the interaction**.
- Not a limit distribution: on a fixed h only $\langle h, \eta_t\rangle = O(t)$.
- Larger than the free noise by t^2/A below t, but saturated by a pinning potential.
- **Pathwise** (convex domination of the norm, Doob): a.s. for $t \geqslant 1$, at finite spatial cutoff, $\sup_x (1+|x|)^{-\varepsilon} |\eta_t(x)| \leqslant C(\omega)\, t^{1+d/2} \sqrt{\log(2+t)}$.

Infinite volume

On $\mathbb{T}_L^d$, $V_0(0)$ and V_t are **extensive** ($\sim L^d$). Three **intensive** objects survive:

i. **the force.** For $V_T = \int v_T(\varphi)$, on $\mathbb{R}^d$:

$$\Phi_t = \int_0^t \dot{Q}_s F_s \, \mathrm{d}s + \int_0^t \dot{Q}_s^{1/2} \mathrm{d}W_s, \qquad F_t(x) = -\mathbb{E}_t\big[v_T'(\Phi_T(x))\big].$$

Everything is local; infinite-volume limits should solve this. Uniqueness of solutions $\leftrightarrow$ uniqueness of the theory; non-uniqueness expected at phase transitions (Φ_2^4, deep double well).

ii. **the Burgers flow** of the force;

iii. **differences of free energies** $\mathscr{W}_T^{(L)}(f)$, f local: bounded as $L \to \infty$; basis of the infinite-volume analysis of Φ_2^4 and $\exp(\Phi)_2$.

Estimates must be **local** (weighted norms, volume-independent constants): the analogue of "coming down from infinity". Barashkov–Gubinelli, PMP 2023; Glimm–Jaffe–Spencer 1975

Differences of free energies

Perturb the optimal drift: $u = u^* + w$, $X^u = \Phi + I(w)$, $I_t(w) = \int_0^t \dot{Q}^{1/2} w$. Euler–Lagrange gives the cross term

$$\mathbb{E} \int \langle u^*, w \rangle = -\mathbb{E} \langle D V_T(\Phi_T), I_T(w) \rangle.$$

Proposition. (formal) *The two extensive infima cancel exactly:*

$$-\log \int \mathrm{e}^{-f} \, \mathrm{d}\nu_T = \inf_w \mathbb{E}\left[f(\Phi_T + I_T(w)) + B_{V_T}(\Phi_T, I_T(w)) + \frac{1}{2} \int_0^T \|w\|^2 \right],$$

$B_V(\phi, h) = V(\phi + h) - V(\phi) - \langle D V(\phi), h \rangle$: the **first-order Taylor remainder**.

- Minimiser: $\Phi^f = \Phi + I(w)$ solves the FBSDE with terminal potential $V_T + f$, a perturbation of Φ:

$$F_s^f - F_s = -\mathbb{E}_s[D f(\Phi_T^f) + D V_T(\Phi_T^f) - D V_T(\Phi_T)].$$

Infinite-volume measures

Local interaction $V_T = \int v_T(\varphi(x))\,\mathrm{d}x$:

$$B_{V_T}(\phi, h) = \int b_T(\phi(x), h(x))\,\mathrm{d}x, \qquad b_T(a,h) = v_T(a+h) - v_T(a) - v_T'(a)\,h.$$

- $b_T(a,0) = 0$: only the region where the perturbation acts counts. Every term is **intensive**: no free energy, only Φ and its perturbation.
- f local $\Rightarrow$ the optimal w should decay away from its support, at the rate of decay of correlations.
- Several solutions of the FBSDE (phase transitions) $\Rightarrow$ several measures, each with its own principle.
- Φ^4_3: the remainder term carries the counterterms; the change of variables of Barashkov–Gubinelli is still needed.

Formal statement. An infinite-volume measure is the law of Φ_T for a solution of the infinite-volume FBSDE satisfying the relative variational principle for all local f.

Appendices: additional material

Lecture 4

A semigroup of renormalisation maps

$\mathcal{R}_S(V) = -\log\,(\mu^S * \mathrm{e}^{-V})$. Since $\mu^S * \mu^{S'} = \mu^{S+S'}$,

$$\mathcal{R}_S \circ \mathcal{R}_{S'} = \mathcal{R}_{S+S'} = \mathcal{R}_{S'} \circ \mathcal{R}_S, \qquad V_t = \mathcal{R}_{Q_{T,t}}(V_T):$$

an orbit of an **abelian** semigroup indexed by the cone of positive covariances, nonlinear on V, linear on e^{-V}. Generators:

$$\mathcal{P}_B(V) = \tfrac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}(B\,D^2 V) - \tfrac{1}{2}\langle D\,V, B\,D\,V\rangle, \qquad \partial_t V_t = -\mathcal{P}_{\dot{Q}_t}(V_t).$$

Proposition. (Flatness) (formal) $[\mathcal{P}_B, \mathcal{P}_{B'}] = 0$. *$V_t$ depends on the profile only through $Q_{T,t}$; $V_0(0)$ and ν_T only through Q_T.*

Different profiles with the same endpoints are different **coordinate systems** on the same RG trajectory: they change Φ and intermediate observables, not the terminal theory. **No holonomy.**

Perturbation theory and counterterms

Gaussian convolution **lowers the Wick ordering**: $V_t = \int [\lambda{:}\phi^4{:}_t + \gamma_T {:}\phi^2{:}_t] + O(\lambda^2)$, the dual of $\int H_4(X_t; c_t)$ being an observable. At second order, $S = Q_{T,t}$:

Proposition. (formal) *To second order in* λ*:*

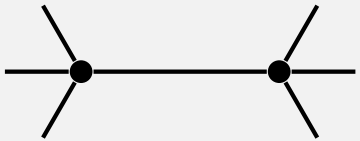
$$V_t = \int [\lambda{:}\phi^4{:}_t + \gamma_T {:}\phi^2{:}_t] - \frac{\lambda^2}{2} \sum_{k=1}^{4} \binom{4}{k}^2 k! \iint S(x,y)^k \, {:}\phi^{4-k}{:}_t(x) \, {:}\phi^{4-k}{:}_t(y) + O(\lambda^3).$$

$T \to \infty$ at fixed t, $d = 3$, $G(z) \sim (4\pi|z|)^{-1}$:

- $k = 1, 2$: finite, nonlocal.
- $k = 3$ (**sunset**): $S^3 \sim |z|^{-3}$; local divergence $-48\lambda^2 (\int S^3) \int {:}\phi^2{:}_t$ (+ finite), cancelled by $\gamma_T = 48\lambda^2 \int Q_T^3 = \frac{3\lambda^2}{\pi^2} \log T + O(1)$.
- $k = 4$: vacuum energy $\sim T$; cancels in ν_T.

Renormalisation = choosing V_T so that V_t at **fixed** resolution converges. $\nu_t \ll \mu^{Q_t}$ expected for $t < \infty$; the terminal Φ^4_3 is singular w.r.t. the GFF.

Second order in graphs



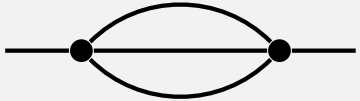
$:\varphi^6:$

tree, finite



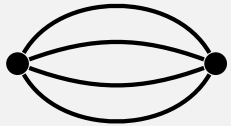
$:\varphi^4:$

bubble, finite in $d = 3$



$:\varphi^2:$

sunset, $\sim \lambda^2 \log T$



1

vacuum, a constant

k lines S between two Wick-ordered vertices. Only the sunset needs a further counterterm, γ_T.

Stochastic localisation: what and why

Eldan 2013: write a measure as a mixture of simpler ones, by a measure-valued martingale. Here

$$\mu_t^{\phi}(\mathrm{d}y) \propto \mathrm{e}^{\langle j,y\rangle - \frac{1}{2}\langle y, \mathscr{R}_t y\rangle}\, \nu_T(\mathrm{d}y), \qquad j_t = S_t^{-1}\Phi_t = \mathscr{R}_t \Phi_T + N_t, \quad \mathbb{E}[N_t^{\otimes 2}] = \mathscr{R}_t:$$

a noisy **measurement** of Φ_T with signal-to-noise $\mathscr{R}_t$, and μ_t the **posterior**. Basic (identity-control) case: $\mathscr{R}_t = t$.

- **Martingale:** Itô splits variance and entropy into revealed and hidden parts.
- **Simpler pieces:** ν_T log-concave $\Rightarrow$ μ_t is $\mathscr{R}_t$-uniformly log-concave.
- **One quantity:** the loss is governed by Cov_t, with explicit dynamics. An inequality reduces to: *the localisation is not too fast*.
- **Algorithms:** sampling (El Alaoui–Montanari–Sellke), denoising diffusions (Montanari); η_t is the score, up to J_t.

Entropy along the localisation

$\rho \geqslant 0$, $\mathbb{E}_{\nu_T} \rho = 1$, $M_t = \mathbb{E}_t \rho(\Phi_T) = G_t(\Phi_t)$, $G_t(\phi) = \int \rho \, \mathrm{d}\mu_t^\phi$.

- $M_0 = 1$, $M_T = \rho(\Phi_T)$, and $\mathrm{d}M_t = \langle D G_t(\Phi_t), \dot{Q}_t^{1/2} \mathrm{d}W_t \rangle$.
- Itô for $M \log M$:

$$\mathrm{Ent}_{\nu_T}(\rho) = \frac{1}{2} \mathbb{E} \int_0^T \frac{\mathrm{d}\langle M \rangle_t}{M_t} = 2 \, \mathbb{E} \int_0^T \left\| \dot{Q}_t^{1/2} D \sqrt{G_t}(\Phi_t) \right\|^2 \mathrm{d}t.$$

- Stopping at t: **revealed + hidden** entropy,

$$\mathrm{Ent}_{\nu_T}(\rho) = \mathrm{Ent}(M_t) + \mathbb{E} \, \mathrm{Ent}_{\mu_t^{\Phi_t}}(\rho).$$

- The increments see the conditional law: $D G_t(\phi) = S_t^{-1} \mathrm{Cov}_{\mu_t^\phi}(\rho, y)$.
- **Entropic stability** (Chen–Eldan): if $\dot{\mathscr{R}}_r \mathrm{Cov}_{\mu_r^\phi} \dot{\mathscr{R}}_r \leqslant \alpha_r \dot{\mathscr{R}}_r$ for all ϕ and $r \leqslant t$, then $\mathrm{Ent}_{\nu_T}(\rho) \leqslant \mathrm{e}^{\int_0^t \alpha_r \mathrm{d}r} \, \mathbb{E} \, \mathrm{Ent}_{\mu_t^{\Phi_t}}(\rho)$: the low resolutions must not hide too much.

Bauerschmidt–Bodineau–Dagallier, Probab. Surveys 2024: their fluctuation measure is our stochastic localisation (scale reversed).

Multiscale Bakry–Émery

Theorem. (Bauerschmidt–Bodineau) (formal) *If for all t, ϕ, with $\kappa_t \in \mathbb{R}$ (possibly negative),*

$$\dot{Q}_t D^2 V_t(\phi)\, \dot{Q}_t + \frac{1}{2}\ddot{Q}_t \geqslant \kappa_t \dot{Q}_t,$$

then $\mathrm{Ent}_{\nu_T}(\rho) \leqslant \frac{2}{\gamma}\, \mathbb{E}_{\nu_T} \| \dot{Q}_T^{1/2} D\sqrt{\rho}\|^2$, $\frac{1}{\gamma} = \int_0^T \mathrm{e}^{-2\int_t^T \kappa_r \mathrm{d}r}\, \mathrm{d}t$.

- Gradient bound at each scale + entropy formula. Gaussian check: $V_T = 0$, $Q_t = t\, Q_T / T$, $\kappa = 0 \Rightarrow$ Gaussian LSI.
- Convexity of the **effective** potentials, not of V_T.
- By $D^2 V_t = S_t^{-1} - S_t^{-1} \mathrm{Cov}_t\, S_t^{-1}$, for $\dot{Q}_t$ invertible the hypothesis is equivalent to the bound, uniform in ϕ,

$$\mathrm{Cov}_t \leqslant S_t - S_t \dot{Q}_t^{-1} \left(\kappa_t \dot{Q}_t - \frac{1}{2}\ddot{Q}_t \right) \dot{Q}_t^{-1} S_t:$$

  at most S_t iff $\kappa_t \dot{Q}_t \geqslant \frac{1}{2}\ddot{Q}_t$ (linear profile: $\kappa_t \geqslant 0$).

Poincaré from the localisation

Proposition. *If* $\dot{\mathscr{R}}_r \operatorname{Cov}_{\mu_r^\phi} \dot{\mathscr{R}}_r \leqslant \alpha_r \dot{\mathscr{R}}_r$ *for all* ϕ, $r \leqslant t$, *then*

$$\operatorname{Var}_{\nu_T}(f) \leqslant \mathrm{e}^{\int_0^t \alpha}\, \mathbb{E} \operatorname{Var}_{\mu_t}(f),$$

and, for ν_T *log-concave,* $\operatorname{Var}_{\nu_T}(f) \leqslant \mathrm{e}^{\int_0^t \alpha}\, \mathbb{E}\langle Df, \mathscr{R}_t^{-1} Df\rangle$.

Proof. $v(r) = \mathbb{E} \operatorname{Var}_{\mu_r}(f)$ has $v' = -\mathbb{E}\langle \chi, \dot{\mathscr{R}} \chi\rangle$, $\chi = \operatorname{Cov}(f, y)$; Cauchy–Schwarz gives $\langle \chi, \dot{\mathscr{R}} \chi\rangle \leqslant \alpha \operatorname{Var}(f)$. Then Brascamp–Lieb for μ_t.

- Gaussian, one mode: $\mathrm{e}^{\int \alpha} = Q_T / S_t$; equality for linear f.
- **KLS conjecture**: isotropic log-concave on $\mathbb{R}^n$, $\mathscr{R}_t = t$: $\operatorname{Var}(f) \leqslant t^{-1} \mathrm{e}^{\int \alpha}\, \mathbb{E}|Df|^2$. Keep $\|\operatorname{Cov}_r\|$ bounded as long as possible (only with high probability). Eldan 2013, Chen 2021, Klartag–Lehec 2022, Klartag 2023: Poincaré constant $O(\log n)$.

Two views of one martingale

this lecture	Bauerschmidt–Bodineau	localisation
ν_t	renormalised measure	law of the tilt
μ_t^ϕ	fluctuation measure	tilted measure
G_t	Polchinski semigroup	martingale $\int \rho \, \mathrm{d}\mu_t$
$D^2 V_t$	Hessian of the potential	covariance of the tilt

- **Bridge:** $D^2 V_t = S_t^{-1} - S_t^{-1} \mathrm{Cov}_t S_t^{-1}$: convex potentials = bounded conditional covariance.
- **Bauerschmidt–Bodineau:** Bakry–Émery for the Kolmogorov equation, curvature $\dot{Q} D^2 V_t \dot{Q} + \frac{1}{2} \ddot{Q}$: gradient bound at each scale, LSI at the terminal scale, far from log-concavity. Uniform in ϕ: suits the RG (sine-Gordon, $\beta < 6\pi$).
- **Localisation:** bound what is lost on $[0, t]$, then use a known inequality for μ_t. Moments of the conditional law, possibly only with high probability (KLS).

Bauerschmidt–Bodineau, CPAM 2021; Bauerschmidt–Bodineau–Dagallier, Probab. Surveys 2024; Eldan, GAFA 2013; Chen–Eldan, FOCS 2022.

Summary

- **Three constructions** of the interacting measure, renormalisation, control and filtering, produce one forward–backward system.
- In **force coordinates** the system has no drift, trees are integrated exactly, and the propagator is the conditional covariance.
- **Potentials:** the value function generates the canonical transformation to these coordinates; the Legendre transform of the filter gives Γ_t and the **Wetterich** equation.
- **Field equation** at every resolution: its noise is a filtered Gaussian noise, hence sub-Gaussian whatever the interaction.

Next

Lectures 5–6: a construction of Φ^4_3 on the torus via the FBSDE.

Exercises and reading

Exercises (numbering of the notes)

- 7.1 Quadratic interactions; 7.2 zero dimensions; 7.3 stochastic maximum principle; 7.5 cost of the leading drift.
- 8.1 Characteristics; 8.4 the constant; 8.6 1PI effective action.
- 8.7 Trees versus loops; 8.8 regulators; 8.9 Brascamp–Lieb; 8.10 the free action.
- 9.2 Relative variational principle; 9.3 DS from the dynamics; 9.5 sub-Gaussian noise.
- A.2 The sunset; A.3 power counting.
- B.1 Entropy along the localisation; B.2 Poincaré from the localisation.

Reading

- Polchinski, Nucl. Phys. B 1984; Wetterich, Phys. Lett. B 1993; Jona-Lasinio, Phys. Rep. 2001; Eldan, ICM 2022.
- Bauerschmidt–Bodineau–Dagallier, *Stochastic dynamics and the Polchinski equation*, 2024.
- Barashkov–Gubinelli, *A variational method for* Φ^4_3, Duke 2020.
- Berges–Tetradis–Wetterich, Phys. Rep. 2002.
- Ma–Yong, *FBSDEs and their applications*, LNM 1702.